

ASSISTANT MANAGER ESSENTIALS: LEVEL 1

Assistant Manager Essentials: Level 1 — Level 1: Assistant Manager Essentials — Day 5: Reliability and Growth

Study guide · Self-study

Level 1: Assistant Manager Essentials · Day 5: Reliability and Growth

How to Use This Guide

You are on the last day of Level 1. Days 1 to 4 gave you the map of the role, a way to run your day, a way to lead people, and a way to handle problems and decisions. Today ties those together into one outcome: being the person whose word can be trusted, and being able to show that in a promotion conversation.

Work through each section in order. Write your answers before you read the model answers at the end. The model answers are examples, not scripts. Your words should sound like you.

Keep one thing in front of you all day: your commitments list. Today is about tracking what you promised, keeping promises, and showing the track record. If you do not have one yet, start it now. Start where you are.

Today's Objectives (KASU)

Knowledge: You will know how to keep a single commitments list, write a short weekly update to your manager, keep records someone else can pick up, and use A.R.T. when you receive feedback you do not fully agree with.

Attitude: You will treat reliability as a behavior you can see and measure, not a personality trait you are born with, and treat escalation as a strength.

Skill: You will be able to hold your routines steady under pressure, and to answer feedback you disagree with before you decide what to do with it.

Upskill: You will be able to run a promotion conversation on your record rather than adjectives, and plan your first 90 days as three short phases.

Track Your Commitments in One Place

Most people who lose trust do not lose it in one big event. They lose it in small slips that nobody wrote down. You agreed to send something on Tuesday, you agreed to check with another team about a date, you agreed to ask your manager about a policy. Each one felt small at the time. Then a week passes, three of them are gone from memory, and someone else remembers.

Psychology explains why this happens. Your mind holds several open items at once, and each one takes a little attention whether you like it or not. When the number grows, the mind quietly drops the ones with no reminder attached, and it usually drops the ones with the longest gap. The client or colleague who was told "I'll come back to you" does not drop it. The gap between your memory and their expectation is where trust leaks.

A single list closes that gap. One place. Everything you promised, to anyone, with a date. Not three lists in separate apps or notebooks. One.

Write each commitment as a short line: what you promised, to whom, and the date it is due. Review it at the start and end of each day. If twice a day is too much, review it once, at the same time every day, so the review itself becomes a routine you never skip.

Practice example: You have made 9 promises this week. Your list has 6 of them. The other 3 are ones you made in passing: a date check for a colleague, a reply about a supplier question, and a note to confirm a meeting time. On Thursday a colleague asks about the date check. You have forgotten it. That is the slip that costs you, not the six you tracked.

There is a useful habit here that takes ten seconds. When you promise something, say the date out loud and write it down before you leave the conversation. What gets written gets kept.

> **NOTES**
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> Look for the promises you made in passing. Those are the ones missing from most lists.

The Weekly Update

Your manager has one job that competes with everything else: knowing what is true. When they do not know, they guess, and their guesses tend to be cautious about you. A short weekly update is how you remove the guessing.

It does not need to be long. Five parts, each a few lines: progress, numbers, risks, decisions needed, and what comes next. That is the whole structure. Progress is what moved forward. Numbers are the facts you have. Risks are the things that might not go to plan. Decisions needed is where you name what you want from your manager, with your recommendation. Next is what you plan to do in the coming week.

Why does this work so well? Because it changes your manager's job from asking you to reading you. It also builds trust the way a bank account works: every kept promise and every honest update is a deposit, and every letdown is a withdrawal (Covey, 1989). Most people make deposits in person and then go quiet when things go wrong. The update keeps you making deposits even in a bad week.

The risks line is the hardest part for many people. The instinct is to hide the thing that isn't going well. But a risk named early is a plan; a risk discovered late is a failure. When you report your own slip before someone finds it, your manager learns something valuable about you: your early warning can be trusted.

Practice example: A weekly update has these lines. Progress: the two training sessions ran, the schedule is out. Numbers: 4 of 6 scheduled sessions complete. Risks: the supplier for the new kit may be late, so session 6 could move. Decisions needed: approve moving session 6 to the following week, which I recommend. Next: confirm the supplier, send the revised schedule.

Notice the decisions line carries a recommendation. That is the habit from Day 1. You are not reporting a problem and waiting. You are bringing a decision with your thought attached.

> **NOTES**
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> Write the update even in a week where little went well. That is exactly the week it matters.

Records Someone Else Can Pick Up

Imagine you are out for a week. Can a colleague open your work and know what to do? If the answer is no, your reliability depends on your presence. That is fragile.

Good records have three qualities. They are simple enough to keep, findable by someone who did not make them, and current. A short note in one agreed place beats a detailed system nobody opens. Each record should show the situation, the decision, and the reason, so the next person understands why, not just what. Where authority matters, the record should also show who approved it.

The psychology is about reducing the effort someone else has to spend. A new person picking up your work has no memory to rely on. Every missing detail forces them to ask, guess, or wait. Each one costs them time and, worse, makes them less sure the job is under control. Clear records remove that effort and pass on your certainty, not just your tasks.

Practice example: You are out on leave. A colleague opens your folder. One record says: "Shift handover changed to 8:00 from 8:30, agreed with the team on Tuesday, approved by the duty manager for two weeks. Reason: the early delivery needs someone on the floor. If the delivery time changes, revert to 8:30." The colleague knows what changed, why, who said yes, and what would undo it. That is a record that holds.

> **NOTES**
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> Test every record with one question: could a stranger act on this without calling me?

Receiving Feedback You Disagree With, Using A.R.T.

You will now use A.R.T., MEDJAY's own framework, which you met on Day 3. You used it for pushback from a team member. Here you use it on yourself: on a piece of feedback you do not fully agree with. The three steps stay the same.

Acknowledge: Name what the person said, plainly, and how it affected them, with no "but" after it. "You said the summary I sent was late and it held up your review. I can see how that cost you a day." No defending, no explaining, no "but I only got the figures on Thursday."

Reframe: Shift from defending your work to what the change would protect for the team. The question changes from "was I right?" to "what would this protect?" If the summary arrives on time, the review starts on time, the team is not waiting, and the next handover is calmer. You are not agreeing to everything. You are looking at the same fact from the team's side instead of your own.

Transition: Ask an open what or how question. "What would a summary that worked for your review include?" or "How early would it need to land to protect your timeline?" A what or how question asks the person to build the fix with you. A yes/no question gets you a polite agreement and nothing you can act on.

The psychology of receiving feedback is that defensiveness is fast and automatic. The first response to a criticism is often a quiet urge to explain why the criticism is unfair. That urge is natural, and it usually costs you the useful part of what was said. Acknowledging first slows you down. It gives the

other person proof they were heard, which lowers the heat on both sides, and only then can you look at what the change would protect.

Practice example: A colleague says your notes from a joint meeting left out their part. You think the notes were fair. You say: "You're saying the notes didn't show your work on the delivery plan, and that makes your part look smaller than it was." Acknowledge done, and no "but." Then the reframe: "What I want is for the next set of notes to protect both our parts with the wider team, so nobody has to re-explain." Then the transition: "What would you want the notes to capture next time?" You get a specific list, and you keep the relationship.

Here is a weak version, for contrast only. "Can we agree it was a fair summary?" That is a yes/no question. It invites a polite yes and gives you nothing to change.

> **NOTES**
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> A "but" after the Acknowledge step cancels it. Leave it out and let the pause sit.

Routines That Hold Under Pressure

When a week gets hard, the first things to go are the routines. The huddle is skipped. The commitments list goes unreviewed. The weekly update is not sent. Yet these are exactly the routines that protect you when things are stretched.

A routine is a small repeated act. Its value does not come from any single instance. Its value comes from being predictable. People plan around what you will reliably do. When a routine disappears, they notice, and trust dips.

The way to keep a routine under pressure is to make it small and fixed. A short huddle at the same time. A list reviewed in the first ten minutes. An update sent on the same day each week, even if it is brief. Small and fixed beats ambitious and irregular. A two-line update that arrives every week builds more confidence than a detailed one that arrives some weeks.

This is the behavior, not the title, that earns credibility. People follow what you do repeatedly, not what your role name says. Repetition is how they learn what to expect from you.

> **NOTES**
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> Decide now which single routine you will protect when the next busy week hits.

Showing You Are Ready: The Promotion Conversation and Your First 90 Days

When you ask for the role, the people deciding will weigh two things: what they have seen you do, and what they believe you would do next. Your record answers the first. A short plan answers the second.

Use evidence, not adjectives. "I'm reliable and I'm ready" asks them to trust a claim. "I have kept a weekly update for months, my routines held through the busiest period, and I acted on the feedback I was given" asks them to look at facts. Credibility in a new role comes from behavior people have already watched, not from the title you are asking for (Hill, 1992).

Keep the case to three parts. What you keep doing: the routines and habits that already work and that you would carry into the role. What you changed: something you got wrong, what you did about it, and what is different now. What you would focus on first: the two or three things you would put right or steady in your first months. The middle part matters most. Anyone can list strengths. Showing a change you made, with the feedback behind it, shows you can learn on the job.

Close with an open question, not a request for a verdict. "What would you need to see from me over the next quarter to support me for the role?" That question turns a yes-or-no moment into a working conversation, and it gives you a concrete list to act on. A "Can I count on your support?" question gets you a polite answer and nothing to work with.

Then plan your first 90 days in three short phases, so the plan is simple enough to say out loud. First 30 days: learn. Meet each team member, understand their work, keep your commitments list, and learn what the team is measured on. Days 30 to 60: fix one thing. Pick the single most fragile routine or record and make it work without you. Days 60 to 90: set the rhythm. Hold the regular review, agree the first targets with the team, and report on them.

Practice example: In an interview you say, "First 30 days, I would learn each team member's work and keep my commitments list. Days 30 to 60, I would make the handover record pick-up ready, because that is where we lose time now. Days 60 to 90, I would hold the weekly review and set our first targets." Then you ask: "What would you want to see in the first month to know it was working?"

> **NOTES**
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> Say the 90-day plan out loud until it takes about a minute. A plan you can say plainly sounds like a plan you can run.

Apply It in Your Role

If you are not an Assistant Manager yet, do all of this without waiting for the title. Keep your commitments list. Send your team leader a short weekly update in the five-part structure. Ask for feedback with A.R.T. A person who already works like this is the obvious next appointment.

If you are in your first months, focus on two things: the commitments list and the weekly update. Those two alone will change how your manager sees you.

If you work alone or across shifts, use handover records as your update. Write them so the next person can act without you. For example, "the count was short by two and I have reordered; the next shift should check on arrival" gives the next person everything they need.

Across every setting, the same rule holds: the record you keep and the update you send are your reputation written down.

What Would You Say?

Answer each one in writing before you look at the model answers.

1. A colleague gives you feedback you do not fully agree with: they say your notes from a joint meeting left out their part. Write your Acknowledge, your Reframe, and your Transition question.

2. You made a promise in passing and forgot it. The person has just asked about it. Write what you would say.

3. A busy week is starting. Write a short weekly update using the five parts: progress, numbers, risks, decisions needed, next. Use your own real work.

4. Your manager asks why you think you are ready for the Assistant Manager role. Write your answer and the question you would ask at the end.

Key Takeaways

One list holds every commitment. What gets written gets kept.

The weekly update has five parts: progress, numbers, risks, decisions needed, next. Send it even in a bad week.

Records are reliable only when someone else can act on them without you.

Use A.R.T., MEDJAY's own framework, when you receive feedback you disagree with: acknowledge what was said and how it landed, reframe toward what the change would protect for the team, and ask an open what or how question.

Small, fixed routines hold under pressure. Protect one with purpose.

In a promotion conversation, your record is the evidence and the open question is the close. Plan your first 90 days as learn, fix one thing, set the rhythm.

Reliability is behavior people can see. A track record beats a title.

Quiz

Answer all five. Write your answer before checking the notes.

1. Which of these best describes how to keep your commitments under control?

- **A.** Keep one list with what you promised, to whom, and the due date, reviewed daily
- **B.** Keep several lists in the places where you made each promise
- **C.** Rely on memory and confirm at the end of each week
- **D.** Only track the commitments that your manager knows about

2. Your week has gone badly and one task slipped. What is the strongest action?

- **A.** Wait until the task is finished, then mention it
- **B.** Say nothing unless someone asks
- **C.** Report the slip early in your weekly update, with a plan to recover
- **D.** Report it at the end of the month with the other results

3. What makes a record usable by someone else picking up your work?

   A. It is long and detailed

   B. It is in your own head and you are available to explain

   C. It shows the situation, the decision, the reason and who approved it

   D. It is stored in the place you personally prefer

4. You are using A.R.T., MEDJAY's own framework, on feedback you disagree with. Which question fits the Transition step?

   A. Did you think the notes were a fair summary?

   B. What would a summary that worked for your review include?

   C. Can we agree the notes were mostly accurate?

   D. Should I keep writing the notes the same way?

5. What makes a routine survive a busy week?

   A. Making it large and thorough

   B. Running it only when you have spare time

   C. Dropping it during a difficult week and resuming later

   D. Making it small and fixed, so it happens every time

Upskill Challenge

Complete this in the next 10 working days. If you are not an Assistant Manager yet, do the version marked for team members.

Start your single commitments list today. Record every promise with a date. Review it for five working days and write down how many promises you made in passing that you would have forgotten.

Send your manager one weekly update in the five-part structure.

Ask one person for feedback on a piece of your work using A.R.T. Write down the answer.

Choose one routine to protect under pressure. Run it for the full period.

Team member version: send the weekly update to your team leader, and use a colleague as your feedback partner instead of a manager.

Then write a one-page case for your own readiness. This is the base for a promotion conversation or interview. Use your record, not adjectives. Three parts: what you keep doing, what you have changed, and what you would focus on in your first 90 days if you were appointed. For example: "First 30 days, I would learn each team member's work and keep my commitments list. Days 30 to 60, I would fix the handover record so anyone can pick it up. Days 60 to 90, I would hold the weekly huddle and report our first monthly review." Make it specific and short.

Rehearse it out loud. If you can say it in three minutes and answer one question honestly, your record is doing the talking.

What's Next: Level 2. You will build on these habits with tools for a wider scope. Until then, keep the list, keep the update, keep the routine.

Model Answers

These are examples, not scripts. The principle matters more than the exact words.

1. "You're saying the notes didn't show your work on the delivery plan, and that makes your part look smaller than it was." Why it works: it names what was said and how it landed, with no "but." Then the reframe: "What I want is for the next set of notes to protect both our parts with the wider team, so nobody has to re-explain." Then: "What would you want the notes to capture next time?" Why it works: it moves from defending your work to what the change protects, and ends with an open what question you can act on.

2. "You're right, I promised that and I didn't do it. I'm sorry. I'll get you the answer by end of day tomorrow and I'll put it on my list now." Why it works: it names the slip without excuses, gives a new date, and commits to a change.

3. A short update reads: Progress: this week I finished the schedule and two sessions ran. Numbers: 4 of 6 sessions complete. Risks: the supplier may be late for the last session. Decisions needed: approve moving it to the following week, which I recommend. Next: confirm the supplier and send the new date. Why it works: it is brief, factual, and carries a recommendation.

4. "I have kept a full weekly update for months, my routines held through the busiest period, and I acted on the feedback I was given — including changing how I write meeting notes. If I were appointed, I would learn each team member's work first, then fix the handover record so anyone can pick it up, then hold the weekly review and set our first targets. What would you need to see over the next quarter to support me for the role?" Why it works: the evidence does the persuading, the 90 days come in three simple phases, and the question is open and invites a real answer.

- Quiz answers:
- 1. A. One list reviewed daily catches the promises you make in passing, which are the ones memory drops.
- 2. C. Naming your own slip early with a recovery plan turns it into a plan, not a failure someone else discovers.
- 3. C. A record works when a stranger can act on it, which means it shows situation, decision, reason and approval.
- 4. B. The Transition step is an open how or what question; the others are yes/no questions.
- 5. D. Predictability is the value of a routine, so small and fixed beats ambitious and irregular.

References

Covey, S. R. (1989). The 7 Habits of Highly Effective People. Free Press.

Hill, L. A. (1992). Becoming a Manager: Mastery of a New Identity. Harvard Business School Press.